> instant. Our friend Mr. Joseph Louis Motha has left Bombay on Tuesday night [10 April] and he will be here to-morrow. After his arrival here I shall write to you about all the business you have to do there in connection with the Steamers. Meanwhile, be preaching about Swadeshi-ism to all the friends and persons you meet.[27]

The Swadeshi shipping company was definitely taking off. Merchants had come together. Two chartered steamers had arrived, one after another on 10 and 20 April, though one is not sure about the steam launch. Indigenous enterprise was to go hand in hand with Swadeshi propaganda. The wind was very much in the Swadeshi sails.

Agreement Hits the Rocks

By the beginning of June 1906, a regular Swadeshi shipping service between Tuticorin and Colombo had begun thanks to the agreement with the Shah Line Company. *The Hindu*'s own correspondent reported that the Swadeshi steamer had become 'a formidable competitor to the British India Company which hitherto enjoyed the entire monopoly over the seafaring trade'.[28] Soon more details emerged. From 1 June, another steamer, *Shajan*,[29] leased from Shah Line Company sailed from Tuticorin on Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays, and made return voyages on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays—there was no service on Sundays. Contrary to earlier expectations, *Shah Allum* had not arrived and was now expected only in the latter part of June.[30] However, it is not clear when, or if, it arrived. In early August, VOC was still writing, 'I have just now received information saying that the Steamers start from Bombay on the 9th instant and our brother is travelling on it.'[31]

Despite the reports of the regular service, there were problems between the Swadeshi concern and the Shah Line Company. There was much friction which was perhaps rooted in the initial dawdling and the lack of clarity on the terms of the agreement. Or perhaps Essaji Tajbhoy, a seasoned businessman, was a clever operator while the Tuticorin merchants were naïve and inexperienced. Moreover, nothing could be put past BI; the